## ACTIVITY 6.12

**Research task**

Break into groups and take one of the following participatory cultures to research:

1. remix culture
2. social media activism
3. meme culture
4. fan pages on social media
5. online gaming
6. YouTubers.

Research these topics and explore the communities online. Identify ways in which each culture observes Jenkins' five principles of participatory culture. Report back to your class with a presentation of your findings.

## New media audiences: Parasocial relationships

Parasocial relationships (PSRs) are the development of one-sided relationships formed between the audience and media personalities. In essence, PSRs are emotional connections an individual audience member can develop with an individual who may never reciprocate that emotion – because they have never met.

PSRs can develop for fictional and non-fictional media identities. Any individual can develop an emotional connection to a fictional character; however, they are more obvious when we consider the relationships between social media audiences, influencers and celebrities. Researchers have suggested that there are many positives to audience members forming PSRs. With our favourite celebrities communicating directly into our eyes and ears, through their social media channels in our phones and other devices, it is possible to develop a greater capacity for empathy, understanding and awareness of the world outside our own.

## ACTIVITY 6.13

**Reflection**

As a class, consider who you follow on your social media channels:

1. What do you know about them?
2. How much do you know about them that you wouldn't know about your own friends?
3. Explain how this has happened.

### THE DOWNSIDE OF PARASOCIAL RELATIONSHIPS

PSRs have existed since the days of the Egyptian pharaohs; however, social media has expanded their reach and capacity to impact audiences. With celebrities and influencers using social media to connect with fans and build their own profiles, they divulge more about their personal lives than was ever imaginable in the broadcast era. A simple comment, like or retweet from this person could suggest that the relationship is genuine (even though most major identities outsource this to media teams!).

Take the case of Belle Gibson, a seemingly relatable Australian influencer who generated thousands of PSRs with her followers through her health journey, which she claimed (fraudulently) to be curing her of brain cancer.

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**FIGURE 6.32** Artist Doja Cat stops for selfies with her fans at Paris fashion week in 2022

Through Gibson's social media profiles, many of her followers emotionally connected with Gibson's health 'journey', and adopted her diet to treat their own chronic conditions. Many were left in significantly poorer health as a result and were ultimately disappointed when it was revealed in 2017 that she was lying about her cancer in the first place.

In some cases, it can go wrong for both the individual and the celebrity. In April 2022, singer Doja Cat announced she was 'quitting music' after the expectations of her fans and her own perceptions of them went awry. Doja Cat's social media was known for her candid and accessible content that connected her with fans. However, in April 2022, in a now deleted tweet, Doja Cat complained that very few fans had come to meet her on tour in Paraguay, yet a barrage of responding comments from local fans suggested that she simply did not make herself available. In this instance, unrealistic fan expectations were not met, and yet the celebrity underestimated the power of the connections they had worked so hard to forge.

## CASE STUDY 6.15




**FIGURE 6.33** Britney Spears fans rally outside the courthouse before the announcement that her father, Jamie Spears, was suspended from her conservatorship in Los Angeles

### #FreeBritney

One of the most remarkable outcomes of PSRs can be found in the 'FreeBritney' movement. Singer Britney Spears had been a global megastar from a very early age. However, fame and **tabloid media** forced her life into a downward spiral, and eventually the overbearing legal '**conservatorship**' of her father severely affected her personal life, leading to her losing control of her assets, wealth and, some believe, control over her own social media accounts.

Spears maintained a loyal and devoted fanbase despite fading from public view some time ago. However, the bland nature of her Instagram account led to two comedians starting a podcast called 'Britney's Gram' that analysed the very basic nature of her posts. Despite her devoted fanbase, she did not appear to use social media in the same way as an artist like Doja Cat. Her posts were erratic, cryptic and often unusually bland. For an artist worth millions of dollars, they lacked the polish and interaction of an established celebrity. Spears' social media also went 'dark' for long and unexplained periods.

An anonymous tip led the podcasters to uncover the true nature of the former pop star's personal life, one that was legally controlled by her father and led to a series of mental health issues for Spears. The hosts, like Spears' legion of fans, had spent hours scouring her posts and developing a PSR with one of the world's most recognisable stars.

**tabloid media** a popular style of largely sensationalist journalism, which takes its name from the tabloid newspaper format: a small-sized newspaper or magazine

**conservatorship** a court order that appoints someone to oversee the financial affairs of a minor or a person who is declared legally incapacitated


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